

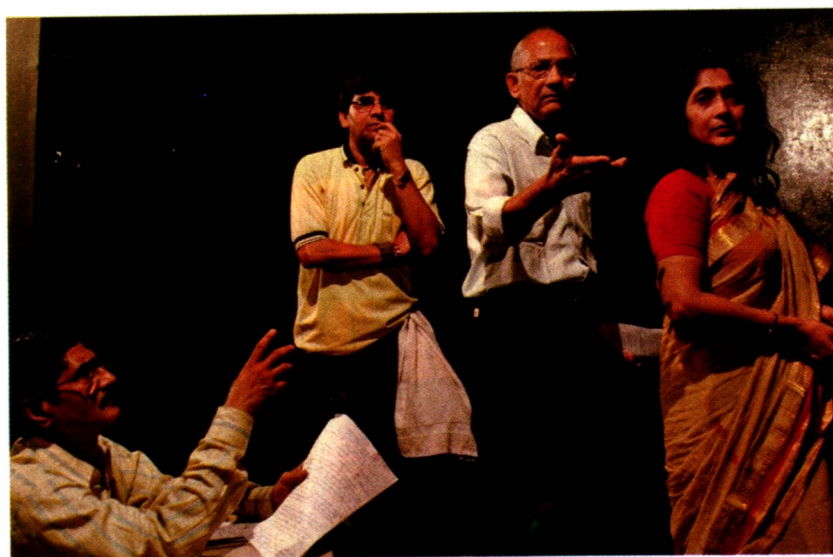
ing out in staccato bursts were difficult to emulate. But in the end, it paid off, I guess. Nobody has acted the part of Basu ever. I am a lucky man."

While the CPI(M) tries hard to stay away from stuff like hagiography, there are some people within the party, however, who will not listen. Ramola Chakraborty, widow of former sports minister Subhas Chakraborty, and founder of the NGO, Pather Panchali, is miffed with the state Government for not allowing Indira Bhawan, Basu's residence for the last two decades of his life, to be turned into a museum. "The party is

there is a small island bang in the middle of a lake. I would want that lake to be named after Basu and install the wax statue there." It would look funny to say the least but Ramola, as she herself says, was very close to Jyoti Basu who, if anything, did not seem to have much liking for whatever passed for as frivolous fun in life. Left Front chairman Biman Bose has no time for such enterprises. "Mr Basu himself did not like deification and statues are difficult as far as upkeep is concerned. Most of the times, statues are covered with bird-droppings. We are planning to put up

"National Award winner Goutam Ghosh has already made a great film on the man which really takes you through the man's vision. Any attempt to make a film on Basu will need meticulous research. He is too close to history for us and too big a man too," he said.

To cap efforts to keep Basu as a reminder every moment in Bengal at least, and that too before the Assembly elections scheduled for 2011, Ramola has taken an initiative to rename the sprawling Brigade Parade Grounds after Basu, a place which is what the Boat Club Lawns



(LEFT) A STILL FROM THE SHOW; BASU LOOKS AT HIS WAX STATUE



not interested and I do not know why the leaders are not pressing for it. We need to remember that everything Basu used is still in that house. Soon, pilferage will start and the place will cease to be looked after properly. If we had converted it into a Basu museum, then this could have been avoided." But undaunted, she continues her own personal plans for keeping Basu alive as a god of sorts. A lifesize wax statue is ready and Ramola is busy trying to get the burgeoning satellite township New Town named after the former chief minister. "While going to New Town,

an oil portrait of our leader in the state secretariat."

But from news coming in from Chandigarh, the hagiography of Basu does not willy-nilly stop in Bengal. The national convention of the CITU which ended there on March 21 was named Comrade Jyoti Basu Nagar and photographs splashed all across newspapers and televisions from the venue showed pictures, cutouts and roses being not only prominently displayed but hogging the show as it were. And with the jatra being such a hit, can a film be too far behind? Haranath Chakraborty, who is one of the biggest names in the film industry in Bengal, has been approached by an NGO to make a film on Basu.

are to Delhi. "Nobody has given more political speeches at the Brigade than Basu. It would be in the fitness of things to rename the Brigade after him."

The fight over Basu continues and the man who was closest to the former chief minister for 30-odd years as Basu's ADC, Joykrishna Ghosh, simply sighs: "What is the point? A jatra, a film, wax statues, an island being named after him... what sense does all this make? The man himself hated all this. All he wanted was to return home and we failed. I wish not to talk about his memories. He will be alive in my heart always."

If only some people would keep it at just that. ■